**IN THE MID-1970S,** a small group of young kids decided to start a 'kindness club' for rescued stray animals under New Delhi's Defence Colony flyover. "We were given space by the then prime minister, Indira Gandhi. We found so many distressed, injured and abandoned animals," says Geeta Seshamani, who was one of the kids. The group went on to set up Friendicoes SECA for assisting street animals in 1979, and has remained committed to animal welfare ever since. Seshamani has been with the NGO since its inception. In 1995, she also co-founded the NGO Wildlife SOS.

"We are bringing up our children without teaching them how to share the world with others," says Seshamani, who returned from the US after a Ph.D. so that her child could experience community wildlife. "I wanted my child to know what it is like to see birds on trees, feed a cow or a dog on the street."

Over the past decade, her NGO has seen many animals with broken limbs, who have been attacked with acid or glass bottles, or even starved or almost beaten to death. "Animal abuse has grown. A single dog bite is hyped up in the media and the perception changes towards community animals. We don't understand them, and if you see pictures of dogs salivating like wolves, you will start to fear them, says Seshamani.

In the past few years, the NGO has also been grappling with abandoned animals and a drop in community feeders, thanks to Covid-19. "During Covid, we had to deal with a huge inflow of abandoned animals. We also had a crisis with thoroughbred horses, a lot of riding clubs were closing down and didn't know what to do with older horses, they were just tied up in fields and abandoned," she says. Friendicoes has been running a mobile equine clinic since. "We had to relocate them to our large animal sanctuary in Gurugram where we now have nearly 200 large animals, including donkeys, ponies, mules."

Friendicoes has also played a huge role in the sterilisation of street dogs and cats, which Seshamani says is the only humane way to manage population. But such work requires determination and money. A few years ago, Friendicoes almost closed down. The NGO has also faced many lawsuits, threats and hostility despite having been such an essential part of Delhi's community fabric. "CSR efforts don't recognise community animal programmes. There is more for wild animals, environment, but not so much for the work we do with street animals. Hopefully, this will change," says Seshamani.

Ultimately, it is the trust and gratitude she sees in an animal's eyes that continues to drive her. ■

***–Sonali Acharjee***



**ACCOMPLISHMENT**

**For over 40 years now, Geeta Seshamani has been trying to make life better for India's street animals**

**SHARING IS CARING**

## "Having community animals builds compassion, and teaches people how to share. We're bringing up our children without teaching them how to share the world with others"

**A LIFE OF MEANING**

**Seshamani held a full-time job as a professor of English at Delhi's Gargi College. But it's helping animals, she says, that gave her life true meaning**